

Upon This Rock (Core Values) (3)

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We continue our series of Upon This Rock.

Vision:

Cedar Grove Baptist Church exists to create a space where people and families can *meet* Jesus, *find* community, and *grow* in their faith.

Mission:

Our purpose is to *love* others unconditionally, *learn* about God increasingly, *live* to share Jesus intentionally and *lead* others to Christ continually in Lebanon, TN and throughout the whole world.

If we are going to build this church as God would want it built, we must be committed to both the vision and mission.

These are not just ideas or statements to be memorized...these are truths to live by. However, we cannot be committed to the vision and mission unless we do so with the correct foundation.

Jesus speaks on this in Matthew 16:15-19

Matthew 16:15-19 NASB95

¹⁵ He said to them, "But who do you say that I am?" ¹⁶ Simon Peter answered, "You are the Christ, the Son of the living God."

¹⁷ And Jesus said to him, "Blessed are you, Simon Barjona, because flesh and blood did not reveal *this* to you, but My Father who is in heaven. ¹⁸ "I also say to you that you are Peter, and upon this rock I will build My church; and the gates of Hades will not overpower it.

¹⁹ "I will give you the keys of the kingdom of heaven; and whatever you bind on earth shall have been bound in heaven, and whatever you loose on earth shall have been

loosed in heaven.”

The rock on which we stand as a church is not any one person, it is not any cultural identity, its not a particular music preference, it's not whether we have pews or chairs, it's not any of that!

The rock that Jesus speaks of is the Himself! The chief cornerstone! The profession that He is LORD!

If we do not get this right, we have nothing right.

A big building and many people does not indicate a proper foundation. The Devil is a master manipulator and imitator. If we are going to grow Cedar Grove, may it be because we have the proper foundation.

This is where our core values come in. If we profess Jesus as Lord, this means that we have been made a new creation, therefore, we have a different set of values than those who live according to the flesh.

We have gone over two of the seven already the past two weeks.

First,

I will uphold the sanctity of the family

Just making family important is not what we are talking about here. There are plenty of people who make their family of such importance that they become an idol.

We are to uphold the sanctity of family. That is that our family is sacred. Our family is holy. Our family is focused on the things of God together.

We do not allow the world do dictate or control our family, but rather our family is a priority of ministry and biblical unity.

Next we have,

I will live daily with integrity in thought, word, and deed.

Remember the definition of integrity...

In the Old Testament, the Hebrew word translated “integrity” means “the condition of being without blemish, completeness, perfection, sincerity, soundness, uprightness, wholeness.” Integrity in the New Testament means “honesty and adherence to a pattern of good works.”

When we think with integrity, we will speak with integrity, therefore our actions will also be with integrity.

If any of these three things are off, all three will be affected. Walking in honesty before God and man means you are who you say you are both in private and public.

Our next core value is

Relationships

Pray.

The statement of agreement for this core value is

I will build and grow each of the four relationships represented in the purpose statement of my church.

These should all sound very familiar this morning.

Each one of our mission statement parts speak on our relationships in certain capacities.

The first being...I will build and grow each of the four relationships represented in the purpose statement of my church...

By seeking to love others unconditionally

This speaks of our relationship with others.

Before I go any further I want to emphasize an important part of this series again.

We are attempting to teach you what it looks like to value the right things in your life. This does not just apply to you but also to me as well.

I believe the church has done a great job of coming up with strong vision and mission statements. Many churches have core values that are right on and make sense.

The church does a great job of branding and marketing what they would like to be and be about. So, where is the disconnect?

Our job as members of this church is not simply to repeat words and mottos. If all we do is memorize a few statements just to show that we are “in” we are missing the whole point.

It is not enough to simply know, we must DO.

So what does it look like to love others unconditionally?

It means to love them in the condition they are in.

Jesus spoke on this in John 15:12-13

John 15:12–13 NASB95

¹² “This is My commandment, that you love one another, just as I have loved you. ¹³ “Greater love has no one than this, that one lay down his life for his friends.

What does this have to do with someone’s condition?

Well, what was our condition when Jesus laid down His life for us?

Romans 5:8 NASB95

⁸ But God demonstrates His own love toward us, in that while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us.

Lexham Theological Wordbook ἁμαρτωλός

ἁμαρτωλός (hamartōlos). adj. sinful. *It denotes sinful behavior.*

Lexham Theological Wordbook ἁμαρτωλός

It can be used derogatorily to describe people (Mark 2:16; Jas 4:8); to describe individuals who are guilty of specific sins (Luke 13:2); or to describe humanity's natural relationship to God (Rom 5:8).

This term sinner does not just describe who we are but also what we do. When you came to Christ you did not do so cleaned up already.

We tell people all the time, “you don’t have to clean up to come to Jesus! Jesus does that through His blood!”

When we invite people to church we tell them “just come as you are” that is, until they do...

Do we forget how Jesus found us?

Ephesians 2:1–5 NASB95

¹ And you were dead in your trespasses and sins, ² in which you formerly walked according to the course of this world, according to the prince of the power of the air, of the spirit that is now working in the sons of disobedience.

³ Among them we too all formerly lived in the lusts of our flesh, indulging the desires of the flesh and of the mind, and were by nature children of wrath, even as the rest. ⁴ But God, being rich in mercy, because of His great love with which He loved us,

⁵ even when we were dead in our transgressions, made us alive together with Christ (by grace you have been saved),...

God loved us even before He saved us.

We must love people no matter the condition they are in. This does not mean we tolerate or support their sin. Sometimes the best way to love someone is to love them from afar.

Jesus never tolerated someone's sin, yet Jesus loved the people He came encountered. Unconditional love is not afraid of saying the tough truth in a loving way.

Why? Because our love is not predicated on someone's response to our love.

One of the greatest descriptions of unconditional love is found in 1 Corinthians 13:4-7

1 Corinthians 13:4-7 NASB95

⁴ Love is patient, love is kind *and* is not jealous; love does not brag *and* is not arrogant,

⁵ does not act unbecomingly; it does not seek its own, is not provoked, does not take into account a wrong *suffered*,

⁶ does not rejoice in unrighteousness, but rejoices with the truth; ⁷ bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things.

How easy do we give up on somebody? God help us love others like Jesus loves us.

I will build and grow each of the four relationships represented in the purpose statement of my church...

By growing in our faith through learning about God increasingly

This speaks of our relationship with the Lord and His Word.

This one is a blind spot in too many churches. We come to church and expect to get fed and fed and fed. We pay a preacher to teach us the Bible. We expect volunteers from the church to teach us and our children about God. We have off-loaded a responsibility God gave us individually to someone else. And if we see something or hear something we do not like, we immediately get defensive in self-righteousness.

Let me tell yall something this morning with all the love in my heart. If we are not studying for ourselves at home or teaching our kids ourselves at home, I really do not have time for your opinion or complaint about how we do things here.

If the church is more diligent and effective about teaching your family the Word of God in the 2-3 hours a week we gather than you are with the 165 hours of the rest of the week, folks we have a problem.

Listen, I get it. We do everything we can here at Cedar Grove to teach the Word. It is of the utmost priority for every leader for every ministry.

But we cannot outdo the time you have away from here. We are to be growing in the

faith personally through learning increasingly. This means that we are learning every day.

King David wrote of this in Psalm 25:4-5

Psalm 25:4-5 NASB95

⁴ Make me know Your ways, O LORD; Teach me Your paths. ⁵ Lead me in Your truth and teach me, For You are the God of my salvation; For You I wait all the day.

You show me a carnal and worldly church, ill show you a congregation that is not increasingly learning about God.

We cannot live only off of what we have learned as a kid. Sometimes I feel like people just repeat the same thing over and over again because that's what they first learned about God.

Listen, we've got to go deeper. Don't just believe something because someone you liked or followed told you that's what to believe. Go to God's Word. Learn from Him. You may be surprised.

A thriving church is a church where the people has a hunger for God's Word.

When is the last time you asked God to lead you in His truth? To teach you His ways?

I will build and grow each of the four relationships represented in the purpose statement of my church...

By building up the church through living to share Jesus intentionally

This one and the next one speaks of our relationship with the mission.

Mark 16:14-15 NASB95

¹⁴ Afterward He appeared to the eleven themselves as they were reclining *at the table*; and He reproached them for their unbelief and hardness of heart, because they had not believed those who had seen Him after He had risen.

¹⁵ And He said to them, "Go into all the world and preach the gospel to all creation.

Not everyone is a pastor, but everyone is expected to preach the Gospel.

This truth is derived from what that word “preach” means...

Lexham Theological Wordbook κήρυσσω

κήρυσσω (kēryssō). vb. **to preach or proclaim.** *Refers to publicly preaching or proclaiming a message.*

This is what it is to share the good news of Jesus. The Gospel, the truth that Jesus lived, died for our sons, and rose again the third day...me, you, we ,everyone who is saved is to proclaim this!

It breaks my heart when I hear someone say things like “I just don’t know what to say...” “I cannot go soul winning because I am too shy...”

You’re too shy about the fact that Jesus saved you? God forbid.

All you have to share is what Jesus did for you. And if it’s anything other than what we see clearly in scriptures, you need to get saved yourself!

This brings us to the final part of the day...

I will build and grow each of the four relationships represented in the purpose statement of my church...

By expanding the kingdom of God through leading others to Christ continually

This is what it is all about.

Matthew 28:18–20 NASB95

¹⁸ And Jesus came up and spoke to them, saying, “All authority has been given to Me in heaven and on earth. ¹⁹ “Go therefore and make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and the Son and the Holy Spirit,

²⁰ teaching them to observe all that I commanded you; and lo, I am with you always, even to the end of the age.”

“Well, preacher I am just not one to care about numbers...”

You don't feel that way about your business? You don't feel that way about your bank account? You don't feel that way about when it comes to getting anything else done in your life.

YET, when we get to church all of a sudden it doesn't matter?

Church, listen to me... the more people come to know Christ, the more people will come to know Christ...

Let me say that again in case you missed it. Repeat

Dead churches do not care about numbers because they do not have any. They are filled with believers who have grown cold in their walk. Stagnant in their faith. Apathetic towards the things of God.

Now, that doesn't mean that just because a church is small it is out of God's will. But that church better be going after the lost in community.

You know how we do this?

by *loving* others unconditionally, *learning* about God increasingly, *living* to share Jesus intentionally and *leading* others to Christ continually in Lebanon, TN and throughout the whole world.

May we grow in these four relationships.

I want to leave you with these challenge this morning. The same challenge Paul gave the believers in Rome...

Romans 10:13–15 NASB95

¹³ for “WHOEVER WILL CALL ON THE NAME OF THE LORD WILL BE SAVED.”

¹⁴ How then will they call on Him in whom they have not believed? How will they believe in Him whom they have not heard? And how will they hear without a preacher?

¹⁵ How will they preach unless they are sent? Just as it is written, “HOW BEAUTIFUL ARE THE FEET OF THOSE WHO BRING GOOD NEWS OF GOOD THINGS!”